

Empowering the Traveler: An Examination of the Impact of User-Generated Content on Travel Planning

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ABSTRACT: To understand the role of user-generated content (UGC) in travel planning, this study integrates Psychological Empowerment with the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), to develop a model of UGC-enabled empowerment and its impact on intention to use UGC when making travel plans. Survey data from 268 backpacker tourists revealed that perceived empowerment and perceived usefulness are significant drivers of attitude and intention to use UGC for travel planning. The findings provide the travel industry with a better understanding of how travelers' perceptions of and use of UGC is empowering them to take greater control of the travel planning process.

Keywords: user-generated content, empowerment, technology acceptance model, backpackers.

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Introduction

Today the Internet has far surpassed other sources of travel information, such as friends and family, travel agents, and traditional media (e.g. brochures and magazines) to become a key influence in the travel and tourism sector, with studies showing over 70% of leisure and business travelers use the Internet for travel planning Google (2014). Social media applications such as blogs, electronic social networks, and aggregators of user-generated content (UGC) are especially influential in supporting the creation and exchange of user-generated travel information, opinions and recommendations (Litvin, Goldsmith, & Pan, 2008; Xiang, Wang, O'Leary, & Fesenmaier, 2015). This has led to calls for further research

into the antecedents and consequences of social media use (Leung, Law, Van Hoof, & Buhalis, 2013).

Studies show that looking at comments posted by travelers such as travel reviews has become one of the most important online activities during the travel planning process (Xiang, Magnini, & Fesenmaier, 2015; Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015). One outcome of this use of UGC is its potential impact on traveler empowerment and consequently, on travel planning behavior (Ayeh, Au, & Law, 2016).

The concept of empowerment is not new to the tourism literature (Hjalager, 2001; Sparrowe, 1994). However, most studies focus on employee empowerment (Lin, Wu, & Ling, 2017; Ro & Chen, 2011; Sparrowe, 1994). There is also growing interest in residents' empowerment (Boley, McGehee, Purdue, & Long, 2014). But, despite its importance as a motivator of traveler behavior (Ayeh et al., 2016; Hjalager, 2001) there is little on traveler empowerment.

Research suggests that the wealth of UGC available to travel consumers (Hjalager, 2001; Jalilvand & Samiei, 2012; Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015; Ye, Law, Gu, & Chen, 2011) may help in the empowering process, enabling travelers to evaluate their options and make their own travel choices (Füller, Mühlbacher, Matzler, & Jawecki, 2009; Litvin et al., 2008; Ye et al., 2011). But, while access to travel information is essential, for empowerment to be realized persons must be able to both feel and act empowered, that is, they must be able to exercise personal control over their travel tasks and goals, and make decisions (Conger & Kanungo, 1988; Psorinos, Kern, & Smithson, 2000; Rappaport, 1987; Spreitzer, 1995). The truly empowered tourist is therefore described as “a person who, without much pain or intellectual effort, is able to make an informed choice of services and products in accordance with his/her own preferences” (Hjalager, 2001, p. 289).

To better understand the role of UGC in traveler empowerment, this study examines the impact of traveler perceptions of UGC-related empowerment on attitude, and intention to use UGC for travel planning. More specifically, this paper examines the following question: To what extent does use of UGC enable traveler empowerment and, what is its impact on travel planning (i.e. intention to use UGC for travel planning)?

This study extends prior work on empowerment (Ro & Chen, 2011; Sparrowe, 1994), and on technology acceptance in tourism research (Ayeh, Au, & Law, 2013) by incorporating and validating a multi-dimensional model of empowerment in the context of traveler use of UGC, focusing on intention to use UGC for travel planning. The model is examined using survey data from backpacker tourists. As a younger, more budget conscious, IT-savvy segment it is expected that UGC would play a significant role in travel planning (Paris, 2012). This provides an opportunity to determine to what extent UGC acts as an empowering factor in the travel planning process.

The paper proceeds as follows. The next sections present the literature review and theoretical framework that underpin the study, followed by the research model and hypotheses. The methodology, based on the partial least squares approach to structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) is outlined and the results presented. Finally, the implications for practice and research are discussed.

Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

User-generated content (UGC) describes a form of word-of-mouth that offers non-commercial, experiential and up-to-date travel information (Yoo & Gretzel, 2011). This includes online reviews, comments and opinions created by users of a product or service and made available through social media applications. UGC has many benefits for travelers enabling them to get a good understanding of a travel service or product, reduce pre-purchase

doubt or risk, reduce the search time for travel information, and get ideas for trips or evaluate alternatives (Litvin et al., 2008; Vermeulen & Seegers, 2009).

In this study, we examine traveler use of online travel reviews (OTRs). OTRs consist of comments written and posted by travelers on tourism products, services, and brands they experience (Filieri & McLeay, 2014). As one of the most readily available forms of user-generated travel content (Yoo & Gretzel, 2011), OTRs are often used by travelers during the travel planning process (Xiang, Magnini, et al., 2015; Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015). As such it is likely that OTRs would influence traveler empowerment vis-à-vis travel planning.

Empowerment

Empowerment as a general concept describes a process by which people, organizations and communities gain mastery over issues that concern them (Rappaport, 1987). In this study, the focus is on the individual. Also referred to as *psychological empowerment* (Pires, Stanton, & Rita, 2006; Zimmerman, 1995), individual empowerment describes the enabling of individuals with greater decision-making abilities and discretion to decide how to perform a particular behavior (Conger & Kanungo, 1988).

Empowerment can be viewed as a process or an outcome or both (Zimmerman, 1995). As a process the focus is on the mechanisms by which people become empowered, gaining control and mastery over their own destiny and influencing decisions that affect them (Rappaport, 1987). Empowering processes include opportunities to gain greater access to and control over resources to develop and practice skills, and to gain experiences in which persons learn to see closer connections between their goals and how to achieve them (Thomas & Velthouse, 1990). For travelers this empowering process includes efforts to gain control and access to user-generated travel information via the Internet, and to understand one's context in relation to travel planning (Ayeh et al., 2016; Zimmerman, 1995).

As an outcome, empowerment describes the consequences of the empowering process (Zimmerman, 1995). This view of empowerment includes a person's sense of *personal control* over their actions or decision-making (Rappaport, 1987), as well as a motivation to control their actions, self-efficacy and perceived competence, decision-making and problem-solving abilities, and an awareness of their options and choices to act in ways they believe will help them achieve their goals (Zimmerman, 1995). Building on Conger and Kanungo (1988), Thomas and Velthouse (1990) further describe empowerment as a type of intrinsic task motivation that manifests as changes in four cognitions or task assessments, namely meaning, competence, self-determination (choice) and impact:

- *Meaning* (or 'meaningfulness') represents the value of a task goal or purpose as judged in relation to an individual's own ideals or standards, and involves an individual's intrinsic caring about a task.
- *Competence* defines the degree to which a person can perform a task skillfully when they try.
- *Self-determination* refers to an individual's sense of having choice in initiating and regulating actions.
- *Impact* represents the degree to which a behavior is seen as making a difference in terms of accomplishing the purpose of the task and producing the intended outcomes.

Ultimately, these assessments are determined by their context and they, in turn, determine the extent to which one feels empowered. To understand empowerment well, it is therefore important to consider the context in which it is developed and supported. Next, we examine key technology attributes of the context in which traveler empowerment through UGC is enabled.

Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

To understand the technology aspects of the UGC context for traveler empowerment and travel planning, this study draws on the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) (Davis, 1989). TAM is recognized in the travel and tourism literature as an influential theory for examining both acceptance and use of IT systems such as participation in online travel communities, use of restaurant review websites for sharing knowledge, use of UGC for travel planning, and continued use of social media networks (Ayeh et al., 2013, 2016; Casaló, Flavián, & Guinalú, 2010; Huh, Kim, & Law, 2009; tom Dieck, Jung, Kim, & Moon, 2017; Yang, 2017).

Adapted from the Theory of Reasoned Action, TAM postulates two technology beliefs as key influences on attitude and use intention – perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use (Ajzen & Fishbein, 1980; Davis, 1989). *Perceived usefulness* refers to an individual's beliefs that use of a particular technology enhances performance, while *perceived ease of use* reflects an individuals' beliefs that the technology is easy to use (Davis, 1989). Applied to this study, perceived usefulness represents a traveler's perception that using UGC would improve travel planning, while perceived ease of use reflects a traveler's perception that using UGC for travel planning would be easy. To the extent that UGC is considered useful and easy to use, persons are likely to perceive it as an important tool for travel planning and as essential to the empowering process (Jalilvand & Samiei, 2012; Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015).

Prior studies of IT use have examined the impact of competence, meaning and impact or psychological empowerment (as a whole) on attitude and behavioral intention (Kim & Gupta, 2014; Psoinos et al., 2000; Welschen, Todorova, & Mills, 2012). Applied to travel planning, these studies suggest that empowered travelers are likely to view UGC favorably and use it for travel planning. Research further suggests that perceived usefulness and empowerment may complement each other (Kim & Gupta, 2014; Psoinos et al., 2000) offering a good explanation of traveler use of UGC for travel planning. In bringing together

empowerment theory and the TAM, this study extends the application of TAM in tourism research (Ayeh et al., 2013, 2016; Casaló, Flavián, & Guinalíu, 2011; Yang, 2017) to account for the role of empowerment in determining key attitudinal and behavioral beliefs toward using UGC for travel planning. The research model is shown in Figure 1.

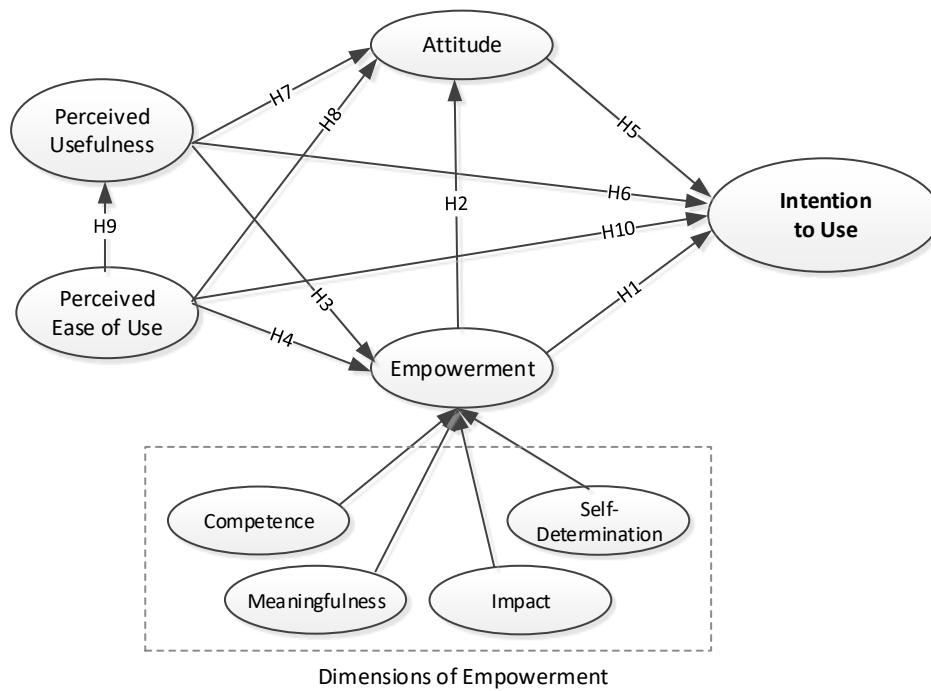


Figure 1. The Research Model

Research Hypotheses

Psychological Empowerment

Psychological empowerment is considered a motivation that controls tasks and helps people to act in ways that accomplish their goals. Although there are no studies focused on UGC-enabled empowerment, research suggests that psychological empowerment has a significant influence on behavior (Fuchs & Schreier, 2011; Füller et al., 2009; Kim & Gupta, 2014; Sparrowe, 1994). For example, Füller et al. (2009) showed perceived empowerment is a significant determinant of consumers' intention to engage in new product development tasks, with each experience potentially increasing people's intention to repeat activities they feel

empowered in. Focusing on employee use of a customer relationship management (CRM) system, Kim and Gupta (2014) showed a strong relationship between psychological empowerment and system usage. Extending these insights to the role of UGC in travel planning, we expect empowered persons are likely to exercise greater control in setting their travel goals and taking appropriate actions, and to make greater use of UGC for travel planning. Hence:

Hypothesis 1: Perceived empowerment positively impacts intention to use UGC for travel planning.

Studies further suggest that psychological empowerment may positively impact on attitude. Focusing on residents' attitudes toward tourism, Boley et al. (2014) found empowerment was a key factor impacting their perceptions of the effects of tourism on their community and their support for tourism. Studies on technology-related attitude also confirm the importance of empowerment (Psoinos et al., 2000; Welschen et al., 2012). For example, research suggests that heightened feelings of competence, meaning and impact, lead to more favorable attitudes towards knowledge sharing (Welschen et al., 2012). Building on these findings and what we know of the empowering role of having access to resources (Harrison, Waite, & Hunter, 2006; Psoinos et al., 2000), this study suggests that travelers who believe that using UGC for travel planning is empowering (Ayeh et al., 2016; Jalilvand & Samiei, 2012), are likely to have more favorable attitudes towards it. Hence it is expected that:

Hypothesis 2: Perceived empowerment positively impacts attitude towards using UGC for travel planning.

Prior studies have not explicitly examined the roles of perceived usefulness and ease of use as antecedents of empowerment. However, studies do allude to the enabling role of technologies such as the Internet and social media (e.g., reviews, comments, opinions) and other information systems (IS) in relation to perceived empowerment (Casaló et al., 2011;

Harrison et al., 2006; Pires et al., 2006; Psoinos et al., 2000). For example, Psoinos et al. (2000) in a study of IS support for employee empowerment found that technology-factors such as access to necessary information influenced empowerment.

Over the last decade the Internet has become increasingly useful and even essential to trip planning, supporting key activities such as destination choice, and deciding on what to eat and where to shop (Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015). In the case of UGC, such content can help travelers make good decisions. The extent to which using UGC for travel planning is perceived as free of effort (Ayeh et al., 2016; Psoinos et al., 2000) may enhance one's sense of control over the travel planning process and increase empowerment. As such, ones' perceptions of the usefulness of UGC in providing access to information for travel planning and ease with which it can be used for travel planning are expected to impact empowerment, making the planning process more meaningful and increasing the travelers' sense of self-determination and confidence in their ability to set goals and make appropriate travel decisions. Hence:

Hypothesis 3: Perceived usefulness of UGC positively impacts perceived empowerment.

Hypothesis 4: Perceived ease of using UGC positively impacts perceived empowerment.

Attitude

Attitude is the degree to which a person has a favorable evaluation of the behavior in question (Ajzen & Fishbein, 1980). The more favorable the attitude towards the behavior, the stronger should be the individual's intention to perform it (Ajzen & Fishbein, 1980). In tourism research, attitude has been associated with intentions regarding destination choice, use of hotel information systems, and using UGC for travel planning (Ayeh et al., 2013; Huh et al.,

2009; Jalilvand & Samiei, 2012). For example, Jalilvand and Samiei (2012) found that use of eWOM impacts attitude and intention toward a travel destination. In a study of leisure travelers, Ayeh et al. (2013) found that attitude towards user-generated reviews positively shaped intention to use UGC for travel planning. Similarly, in a survey of online travel communities, Casaló et al. (2011) found that attitude impacted intention to follow advice received from the community.

Turning to use, prior research suggests a link between attitude and use intention (Huh et al., 2009; tom Dieck et al., 2017; Venkatesh, Thong, Chan, Hu, & Brown, 2011). For example, in a study of citizens' use of eGovernment, Venkatesh et al. (2011) found continuance intention was primarily explained by attitude. Huh et al. (2009) in a survey of experienced users of hotel information systems showed a strong link between attitude and use intentions. tom Dieck et al. (2017) in a survey of luxury hotel guests also found a positive link between attitude and continued use of social media networks. Taken altogether, it is expected that a favorable attitude would encourage travelers to use UGC when making travel plans. Hence:

Hypothesis 5: Attitude towards UGC positively impacts intention to use UGC for travel planning.

Perceived Usefulness and Ease of Use

TAM suggests a direct relationship between perceived usefulness and, attitude and intention and, between perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness and attitude (Davis, 1989). In tourism, research provides strong support for the impact of perceived usefulness on attitude and use intention (Ayeh et al., 2013; Casaló et al., 2010; Huh et al., 2009; tom Dieck et al., 2017). Casaló et al. (2010) found that perceived usefulness had a significant impact on consumer attitude towards participating in an online travel community; tom Dieck et al.

(2017) also demonstrated a strong positive link between perceived usefulness and attitude towards using social media networks . Focusing on travelers, Ayeh et al. (2013) found that perceived usefulness directly impacted attitude and intention to use UGC for travel planning. Altogether, these findings suggest that travelers who see UGC as useful are likely to have favorable attitudes towards and intentions to use UGC for travel planning.

Perceived ease of use has also been positively related to perceived usefulness, attitude and intention (Ayeh et al., 2013; Casaló et al., 2010; Huh et al., 2009; tom Dieck et al., 2017). Casaló et al. (2010) found that perceived ease of use positively influenced perceived usefulness and attitude towards participating in a firm-hosted travel community. tom Dieck et al. (2017) also confirmed the relationship between perceived ease of use and, perceived usefulness and attitude towards social media network use. Similarly, Ayeh et al. (2013) found that perceived ease of using UGC had a positive impact on perceived usefulness and attitude towards using UGC for travel planning. This suggests that if travelers believe that UGC is easy to use this would enhance their attitude as well as their belief that using it would improve travel planning.

For perceived ease of use and use intention, the findings are mixed. Some studies show a direct link between ease of use and intention, while others showed the effect may decline over time with experience and become less important or have no significant impact (Ayeh et al., 2013, 2016; Venkatesh et al., 2011). For example, Venkatesh et al. (2011) found a positive impact for ease of use on continuance intention; Kim and Gupta (2014) also showed a positive link between ease of use and post-adoption (extended) use of a CRM system. By contrast, in a study of Singaporean and American travelers Ayeh et al. (2016) found a direct effect between ease of use and intention to use OTRs for travel planning for Singaporean travelers, but there was no effect observed for American travelers; the difference was attributed to the possibility of Americans being more familiar with using TripAdvisor.

Although prior research is inconclusive, consistent with TAM it is hypothesized that ease of use would influence intention to use UGC.

Taken altogether, the following are proposed:

Hypothesis 6: Perceived usefulness of UGC positively impacts intention to use UGC for travel planning.

Hypothesis 7: Perceived usefulness of UGC positively impacts attitude toward using UGC for travel planning.

Hypothesis 8: Perceived ease of using UGC positively impacts attitude towards using UGC for travel planning.

Hypothesis 9: Perceived ease of using UGC positively impacts perceived usefulness of UGC.

Hypothesis 10: Perceived ease of using UGC impacts intention to use UGC for travel planning.

Methodology

The Sample and Survey procedure

For this study, a survey was conducted of backpacker tourists who have used UGC - specifically online travel reviews (OTRs) - when planning their travel. The term “backpacker” is predominantly used by the tourism industry to describe travelers who have a preference for flexible travel itineraries, longer holidays, budget accommodation, socializing with other travelers, and informal holiday activities (Pearce & Foster, 2007). Research shows backpackers are active users of the Internet (Paris, 2012), with online recommendations such as OTR being influential sources of information when making travel and accommodation decisions (Paris, 2012; Zhang & Watts, 2008). Backpackers were therefore suitable for examining UGC-enabled traveler empowerment and its impacts.

Self-administered paper-based surveys were distributed to backpackers visiting New Zealand and staying in Auckland city hostels. Auckland was selected for data collection as it accounts for more than 70% of international arrivals and departures into and from New Zealand (New Zealand Ministry of Tourism, 2012). Nine (9) city hostels participated in the study; guests were approached in the common areas (e.g. kitchen, reception or lounge) and invited to complete the survey.

Of the 512 surveys distributed, 365 surveys (71%) were returned. Ten surveys were incomplete, and 87 surveys omitted because the respondents had not used OTR for travel planning, leaving 268 usable responses (52%) from OTR users. Of the 355 completed surveys, about three in four respondents (75.5%) had used OTR when planning their travel. For OTR users (n=268), 46.3% used it on a regular basis with 16.4% using it every time they planned a trip; 147 (54.9%) were females and 121 (45.1%) were males. The majority were aged 26-34 years (46.3%) followed by 18-25 years old (42.9%) and 35 years and over (10.8%). For most respondents, their highest level of education was at the undergraduate (45.1%) or postgraduate level (27.2%); the remaining 27.6% were at the secondary level or lower. Thirty-six nationalities were represented with the largest proportions coming from Germany (20.9%) and England (20.1%), followed by the USA (6.0%), France (5.6%), and Canada (5.2%). The most popular OTR websites (used by 20% or more of the respondents) were Booking.com, HostelWorld.com, TripAdvisor.com, LonelyPlanet.com, and HostelBookers.com.

Instrument Development

Survey questions were sourced from validated instruments and modified for this study (Table 1). Consistent with prior studies (Ayeh et al., 2013; Casaló et al., 2010), measures for perceived usefulness, ease of use, attitude and behavioral intention were adapted from Davis

(1989) and Ajzen and Fishbein (1980), while items for perceived empowerment were adapted from Spreitzer (1995). Each construct was assessed using 7-point Likert scales ranging from “(1) Strongly Disagree” to “(7) Strongly Agree”.

The draft survey was evaluated by five academics, and the revised survey pretested with 54 undergraduate students who had used OTRs for travel planning. Their feedback was used to refine the layout and wording, prior to pilot testing with 54 backpackers from a local hostel. The results suggested satisfactory reliability and validity of the measures. Minor changes were made to the layout and wording to further clarify the content for non-native English speakers, prior to the main data collection.

Table 1. Construct Measures

Constructs	Items
Meaning	MEAN1 - Using OTR to make my travel plans is very important to me MEAN2 - Using OTR when I make travel plans activities is significant to me MEAN3 - Using OTR to make my travel plans is meaningful to me
Competence	COMP1 - I am confident about my ability to use OTR when I make my travel plans COMP2 - I believe in my capabilities to use OTR when I make my travel plans COMP3 - I have mastered the skills necessary for using OTR when I make my travel plans
Impact	IMP1 - My use of OTR has significant influence over my travel plans IMP2 - My use of OTR has a large effect on my travel plans IMP3 - The impact of using OTR on my travel plans is large
Self-Determination	SED1 - Using OTR, I can decide on my own how to go about making my travel plans SED2 - Using OTR, I have considerable opportunity for independence in how I make my travel plans SED3 - Using OTR, I have considerable opportunity for freedom in how I make my travel plans SED4 - Using OTR, I have significant autonomy in determining how I make my travel plans
Perceived Usefulness	PUSE1 - Using OTR makes it easier for me to make my travel plans PUSE2 - Using OTR improves my ability to make good travel plans PUSE3 - Using OTR enables me to make my travel plans more quickly PUSE4 - I find OTR useful when I make my travel plans
Perceived Ease of Use	PEOU1 - I find OTR easy to use when I make my travel plans PEOU2 - Learning to use OTR to make my travel plans is easy for me PEOU3 - It is easy for me to become skilful at using OTR to make my travel plans
Attitude	ATT1 - Using OTR when I make my travel plans is a good idea ATT2 - Using OTR when I make my travel plans is a wise idea ATT3 - I like the idea of using OTR when I make my travel plans
Intention to Use	INT1 - I intend to use OTR the next time I make my travel plans INT2 - I intend to use OTR whenever I need to make my travel plans INT3 - I plan to use OTR whenever I make my travel plans

To assess common method bias, Harman's one-factor test (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003) was performed on the 26 items used for the model. The results showed that no single factor accounted for more than 47.7% of the variance observed, suggesting that common method bias was unlikely to be a significant concern for this study.

Data Analysis and Results

The research model was assessed using Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) with SmartPLS 3.2.4 and the bootstrapping procedure (with 1000 resamples) (Ringle, Wende, & Becker, 2015). This approach has been used in travel and tourism research to estimate the relationships implied by the outer (measurement) and inner (structural) models (Ayeh et al., 2013; Tan & Chang, 2016; tom Dieck et al., 2017). It is particularly suitable when the measures includes formative indicators (do Valle & Assaker, 2016) and latent variable scores are needed for subsequent analyses such as second-order modeling of the empowerment construct.

Table 2. Item-level Descriptive Statistics

	Mean	SD ¹	Loadings	Weights		Mean	SD ¹	Loadings	Weights
COMP1	5.653	1.097	0.921	0.380	PUSE1	5.306	1.202	0.886	0.310
COMP2	5.701	0.974	0.924	0.370	PUSE2	5.187	1.157	0.900	0.310
COMP3	5.425	1.221	0.879	0.351	PUSE3	4.929	1.376	0.761	0.240
MEAN1	4.549	1.563	0.885	0.393	PUSE4	5.478	1.035	0.842	0.313
MEAN2	4.399	1.516	0.937	0.364	PEOU1	5.265	1.185	0.885	0.398
MEAN3	4.429	1.498	0.921	0.338	PEOU2	5.321	1.140	0.894	0.354
SED1	5.261	1.171	0.882	0.282	PEOU3	5.325	1.144	0.918	0.361
SED2	5.194	1.13	0.922	0.301	ATT1	5.478	1.131	0.911	0.355
SED3	5.201	1.158	0.912	0.268	ATT2	5.228	1.236	0.929	0.373
SED4	5.131	1.188	0.888	0.258	ATT3	5.306	1.115	0.891	0.371
IMP1	4.373	1.561	0.926	0.367	INT1	5.485	1.223	0.905	0.367
IMP2	4.228	1.592	0.956	0.341	INT2	5.198	1.328	0.965	0.359
IMP3	4.104	1.645	0.943	0.355	INT3	5.026	1.470	0.933	0.344

Key: Competence (COMP); Meaning (MEAN); Self-Determination (SED); Impact (IMP); Perceived Usefulness (PUSE); Perceived Ease of Use (PEOU); Attitude (ATT); Intention to Use (INT).

¹ SD = Standard Deviation

Outer (Measurement) Model

The outer model was assessed by examining the reliability and validity of the construct measures (Chin, 2010). All constructs were modeled as reflective at the first-order level. To assess reliability, factor loadings and internal consistency were examined. Table 2 shows the factor loadings ranged from 0.761 to 0.965, exceeding the recommended threshold of 0.70 for item reliability (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). Table 3 shows that Cronbach's Alpha ranged from 0.870 to 0.936 and composite reliability (CR) ranged from 0.911 to 0.959; both measures exceeded the recommended threshold of 0.707 indicating the constructs are within accepted limits (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994).

Table 3. Cronbach's Alpha, Composite Reliability (CR), Average Variance Extracted (AVE), Variance Inflation Factor (VIF)

	Cronbach's Alpha	Composite Reliability	Average Variance Extracted (AVE)	Variance Inflation Factor (VIF)
Competence	0.894	0.934	0.825	1.230
Meaning	0.902	0.939	0.836	2.342
Self-Determination	0.923	0.945	0.812	1.660
Impact	0.936	0.959	0.887	2.109
Perceived Usefulness	0.870	0.911	0.721	-
Perceived Ease of Use	0.882	0.927	0.808	-
Attitude	0.896	0.936	0.829	-
Intention to Use	0.927	0.954	0.873	-

Convergent validity indicates the extent to which items converge in their representation of the construct they are intended to measure while discriminant validity indicates the extent to which indicators differentiate among constructs (Chin, 2010). Convergent validity was adequate with the average variance extracted (AVE) ranging from 0.721 to 0.887, exceeding the recommended threshold of 0.50 (Chin, 2010). For satisfactory discriminant validity, the square root of the AVE of a measure should exceed the correlations between the measure and all other measures (Chin, 2010); Table 4 shows this to be the case for all constructs.

Table 4. Discriminant Validity and Inter-Construct Correlations.

	Competence	Meaning	Self-Determination	Impact	Perceived Usefulness	Perceived Ease of Use	Attitude	Intention to Use
Competence	0.908							
Meaning	0.312	0.914						
Self-Determination	0.404	0.581	0.901					
Impact	0.333	0.717	0.500	0.942				
Perceived Usefulness	0.403	0.639	0.550	0.687	0.849			
Perceived Ease of Use	0.526	0.320	0.371	0.381	0.459	0.899		
Attitude	0.381	0.569	0.529	0.597	0.716	0.463	0.910	
Intention to Use	0.344	0.605	0.473	0.614	0.689	0.383	0.733	0.934

Perceived empowerment was modeled as a second-order formative construct with four first-order reflective factors - meaning, competence, impact and self-determination (Maynard, Gilson, & Mathieu, 2012; Ro & Chen, 2011). To assess the formative model, two criteria were examined – indicator weights and loadings, and collinearity. The outer (indicator) weights indicate the relative contribution (or importance) of the indicator to the construct, while the outer loadings signal the absolute contribution of the indicator to the construct irrespective of the presence of the other indicators (Hair, Hult, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2014). Both assessments are important for even if an indicator is relatively low in its contribution to a construct, its absolute importance to the construct may be significant (Hair et al., 2014).

The results showed outer weights as follows: meaning (0.284, $p < 0.01$), competence (0.221, $p < 0.01$), impact (0.506, $p < 0.001$), and self-determination (0.238, $p < 0.01$); all were significant (in absolute terms) in respect of empowerment. The following factor loadings were also returned: meaning (0.849), competence (0.573), impact (0.900), and self-determination (0.743). Of these, only competence had a loading below the recommended threshold (of 0.70) and just below the lower threshold of 0.60 for exploratory work (Chin, 2010). Though not ideal since competence is an important task assessment in empowerment, for completeness and consistency with prior research it was retained (Sparrowe, 1994; Spreitzer, 1995; Thomas & Velthouse, 1990).

Unlike reflective models where items are interchangeable, for formative models high correlations between items can be problematic and impact on the estimation of the weights and their significance (Hair et al., 2014). To determine the level of collinearity, the variance inflation factor (VIF) can be examined, where a VIF value of 5 and higher indicates a potential collinearity problem. In this study, VIF ranged from 1.229 – 2.342 (Table 3). Being less than 5, collinearity was not considered an issue.

Inner (Structural) Model

Next, the inner model was assessed by evaluating the R-squared (R^2) values (i.e. explained variances) and path coefficients (i.e., loadings and significance), which indicate how well the data supports the research model (Chin, 2010). Altogether the research model (Figure 2) accounted for 0.612 of the variance explained for intention to use UGC for travel planning. The results show perceived empowerment ($\beta=0.223$, $p<0.01$), perceived usefulness ($\beta=0.223$, $p<0.01$) and attitude ($\beta=0.438$, $p<0.001$) were significant and direct determinants of use intention; H1, H5 and H6 were supported. However, the link between ease of use and use intention was not significant (-0.031); H10 was not supported. Although, no direct impact was shown, further analyses showed the impact of perceived ease of use on intention was fully mediated (0.414) through perceived usefulness, empowerment and attitude.

Turning to empowerment and attitude, the model explained 0.584 of the variance observed for empowerment. Perceived usefulness had the stronger impact ($\beta=0.663$, $p<0.001$), followed by perceived ease of use ($\beta=0.183$, $p<0.01$); H3 and H4 were supported. For attitude, the model explained 0.566 of the variance observed. Perceived usefulness had the strongest impact ($\beta=0.460$, $p<0.001$), followed by empowerment ($\beta=0.268$, $p<0.001$), supporting H7 and H2. Perceived ease of use also impacted attitude ($\beta=0.121$, $p<0.05$) and perceived usefulness ($\beta=0.459$, $p<0.001$), explaining 0.211 of the variance observed for perceived usefulness and supporting H8 and H9.

The total effect of empowerment on use intention was 0.341, with the indirect effect via attitude accounting for 0.118 ($p<0.01$) of the total effect. The direct effect of empowerment on use intention was stronger than the indirect effect via attitude, signaling its importance vis-à-vis intention. Both empowerment and attitude were also important in partially mediating the impact of perceived usefulness on use intention, with a direct effect of 0.223 ($p<0.01$) and total indirect effect of 0.428 ($p<0.001$).

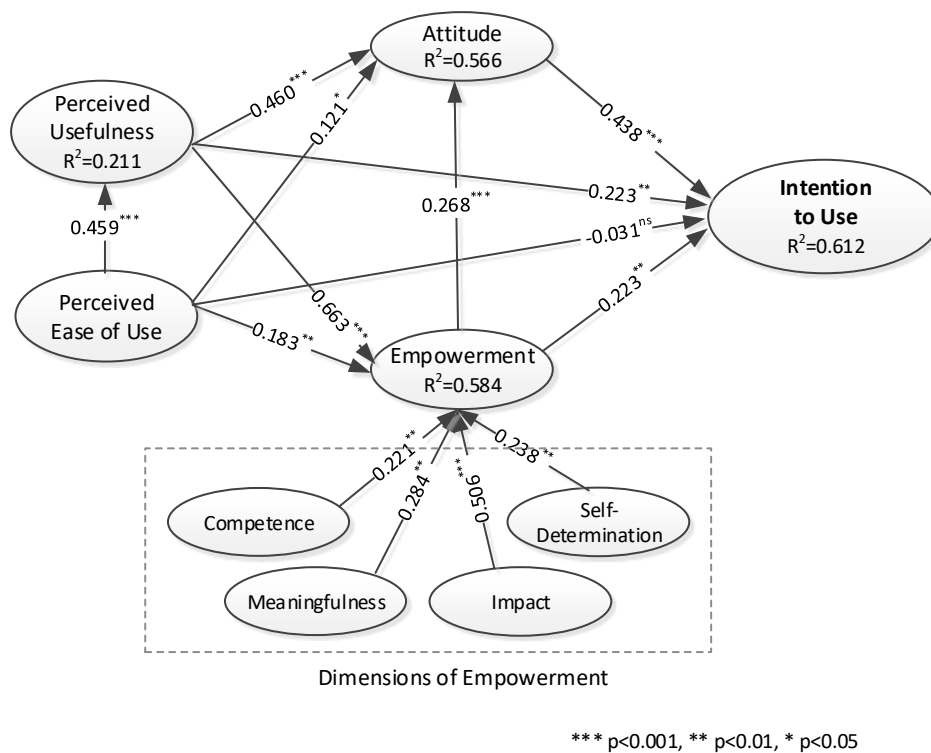


Figure 2. Results

Discussion and Implications

Studies show the Internet is a key source of information for travelers with UGC such as the online travel review playing a significant role in the search for information when people make decisions about their travel (Ayeh et al., 2013; Jalilvand & Samiei, 2012; Xiang, Magnini, et al., 2015; Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015). Given the popularity of UGC and its potential to empower travelers, this study explored the mechanisms through which UGC may empower travelers, and its impacts on attitude and intention to use UGC for travel planning.

The results show that perceived empowerment, together with perceived usefulness and ease of use, had positive impacts on attitude towards using UGC. Consistent with prior research, the results further revealed that the strongest predictor of use intention is attitude (Venkatesh et al., 2011). Perceived empowerment and perceived usefulness also had strong direct effects on use intention. Together these results suggest that travelers are likely to use UGC for travel planning if the content is seen as offering value (i.e. perceived usefulness) and

empowers them in their decision-making. Thus, the usefulness of UGC in providing relevant information and empowerment would appear to complement each other (Psoinos et al., 2000) leading to heightened intention to use UGC in travel planning.

The findings also corroborate research on the importance of the four dimensions of empowerment (i.e., self-determination, competence, meaning, and impact) (Maynard et al., 2012; Ro & Chen, 2011; Spreitzer, 1995; Thomas & Velthouse, 1990), with all contributing to explaining traveler empowerment through UGC. Consistent with prior research, traveler attitude and intentions were strongly influenced by perceived empowerment and its dimensions (Fuchs & Schreier, 2011; Psoinos et al., 2000; Welschen et al., 2012) signaling that empowered travelers are likely to have more positive attitudes toward UGC and use it for travel planning.

Confirming prior research, perceived ease of use had a direct impact on perceived usefulness and on attitude towards UGC (Ayeh et al., 2013; Huh et al., 2009), but not on intentions (Yang, 2017). Instead its impact on intention was fully mediated by perceived usefulness, attitude and empowerment. One possible explanation for this outcome may lie with the hands-on experience that all respondents had, with most having used UGC multiple times for travel planning (Venkatesh et al., 2011). Research suggests that before or in the early stages of hands-on use, one's expectations of ease of use may be determined by their general perceptions of the technology. However, with direct experience, a person's beliefs about the amount of effort needed to use a system, such as UGC, may change over time to reflect that experience. Furthermore, travel consumers would typically not encounter many issues when using UGC. Hence, if they evaluate UGC as easy to use, while ease of use may determine perceived usefulness and attitude, over time its influence on intention may lessen or have little direct impact (Venkatesh et al., 2011).

Implications for practice

As travelers make greater use of social media such as UGC they are becoming increasingly empowered in the travel planning process. It is therefore incumbent that travel service providers (TSP) understand the impacts of empowerment on traveler behavior and in the marketplace (Haussman, 2005), so they can respond well to travelers' needs, and market their products and destinations effectively (Xiang, Wang, et al., 2015).

There is good evidence of the importance of empowering travelers by enabling access to useful user-generated travel information. This is seen in the success of travel-related research websites such as TripAdvisor which provide travelers not only with access to advice from other travelers but also access to information and products provided by TSPs (e.g. hotels, airlines), empowering them to plan, manage and book many aspects of their trips such as accommodation, flights, and tourist attractions. With intimate knowledge of the service and product options available to their market, TSPs can proactively leverage the potentials of social media by incorporating UGC into their services, products and marketing strategies. For example, having a website that provides sufficiently comprehensive and easy-to-use factual information, and consumer-centric channels for reviewing and purchasing travel products can enhance the services that TSPs provide. Hosting online communities that travelers can participate in and share their experiences and promote to others (Casaló et al., 2010) can also help TSPs leverage the potentials of UGC in empowering their consumers, while being able to exercise some control over the content and actions taken on their sites.

At the same time, with so much travel-related UGC online, travelers can often become confused about their choices and inefficient in their planning. This creates opportunities for TSPs to complement UGC resources with online advisory services (e.g. expert advice and decision support) that help travelers navigate and make sense of the information they have (Li & Gregor, 2011; Vermeulen & Seegers, 2009). Empowering travelers to self-assess their

options and become more autonomous in their decision-making can make the travel planning experience more meaningful to the individual and reduce their dependency on the travel expert for all their planning tasks, such as the time-consuming task of information-searching (Li & Gregor, 2011). This can improve operational efficiencies and allow travel experts to focus on more profitable and complex value-adding tasks.

At the same time enabling traveler empowerment can come with “a sting of unintended and largely uncontrolled consumer power” (Pires et al., 2006, p. 937) , if travelers take their business elsewhere being perceived as “the best provider in empowering customers” (Pires et al., 2006, p. 946), and having good incentive systems that enhance loyalty, may help ensure that TSPs benefit from empowering the traveler consumer.

Implications for Theory

Empowerment is not a new concept in the tourism literature (Hjalager, 2001; Sparrowe, 1994). However, there is very little on traveler empowerment, with most studies focused on employees and emerging interest in residents’ empowerment (Boley et al., 2014; Lin et al., 2017; Ro & Chen, 2011; Sparrowe, 1994). Using a sample of backpacker tourists, this is one of the first studies to conceptualize and empirically evaluate the role and impact of traveler empowerment through UGC on travel planning.

In particular, the findings show perceived empowerment is a key predictor of attitude and intention to use of UGC in travel planning, underscoring its importance in travel-related decision-making. The findings contribute to the travel and tourism literature by providing empirical evidence of the mechanisms (i.e. meaning, competence, impact and self-determination) through which travelers are increasingly empowered, by way of UGC, to take charge of their travel choices and decision-making (Harrison et al., 2006; Pires et al., 2006). The study therefore addresses a gap in the literature providing an empowerment perspective

that can be used to explain further, traveler behavior in contexts where increasing access to and use of ICTs and user-generated content impacts behavior.

Outside the findings on empowerment, this study also goes beyond the acceptance and initial use studies to explore post-adoption system use. More specifically, this study extends prior research on traveler behavior and the impacts of UGC (Ayeh et al., 2013, 2016; Filieri & McLeay, 2014; Leung et al., 2013) highlighting the importance and consequences of traveler empowerment through UGC, and of perceived usefulness, perceived empowerment and attitude in relation to post-adoption use of UGC for travel planning.

Limitations and Future Research

Research suggests the informational power held by travel agencies may shift as travelers turn more to online communities for travel advice (Casaló et al., 2011). However, prior research has yet to examine whether increased access to information is actually empowering to the individual. The current study sought to address this gap by providing insights into travelers' use of UGC and its role in empowering them in their travel planning. At the same time, there are elements that may limit application of the findings to other settings and which provide opportunities for further work. First, this study focused on backpackers who are the kind of tourists that typically use online travel reviews (Zhang & Watts, 2008). However, the findings may differ for other traveler categories such as coach tourists, tourists visiting friends and family, travelers seeking comfort, and business travelers. The study also addressed only one type of UGC, namely the online travel review. While the results may apply to other types of UGC such as blogs and digital media (e.g. Flickr, YouTube), this would need to be assessed in future research. The study was also cross-sectional in nature. Thus, it was not possible to assess the temporal ordering of the constructs. Use of qualitative methods or longitudinal study may address this limitation and provide further insight into the relationships studied.

The current study focused on the enabling role of UGC in empowering travelers and its impact on attitude and intention to use UGC when planning travel. Both perceived usefulness and ease of use were shown to be related to empowerment. However, other factors may also be meaningful. For example, people also need to know whether the information they have is reliable and can be trusted. Informational cues such as source credibility, review consistency and argument quality that help travelers evaluate online reviews (Cheung, Sia, & Kuan, 2012; Tan & Chang, 2016) may therefore impact empowerment. Trustworthiness and social identification with an online community (Ayeh et al., 2013; Casaló et al., 2010) may also impact traveler attitudes and use intentions toward UGC. Future research can extend this study by examining other variables that complement and influence traveler empowerment.

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